

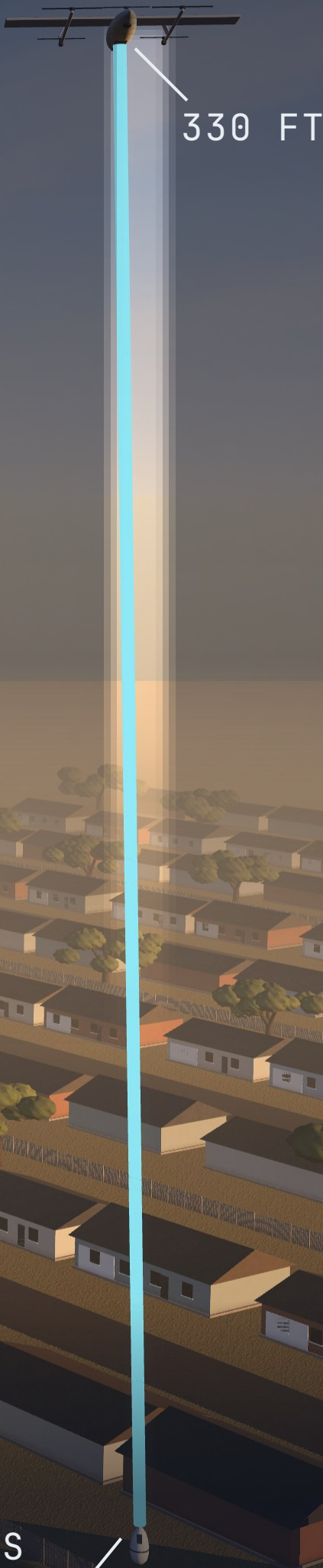
The pod checks the spot

Zipline wants FAA approval to fly delivery drones over Houston, San Antonio, Austin, Amarillo and El Paso. The FAA takes comment until October 11th.



It holds at 330 feet

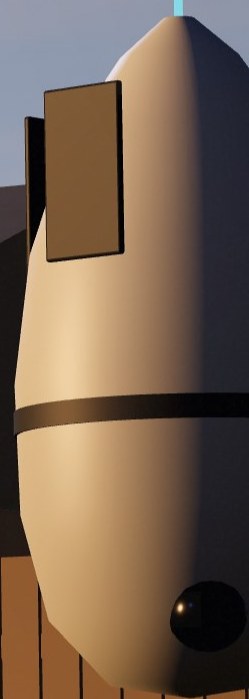
The pod goes down on a line and back up while the aircraft hovers, for about 75 seconds. The aircraft, the pod and the line are drawn larger than they are.



THE POD, ABOUT 75 SECONDS /

It judges the yard

On the way down the pod steers itself sideways and evaluates the spot. If the spot is clear, it keeps descending.



When it can't tell

If the pod can't identify the target and judge it, the draft says an image goes to an operator for real-time evaluation. The draft gives no figure for how often.

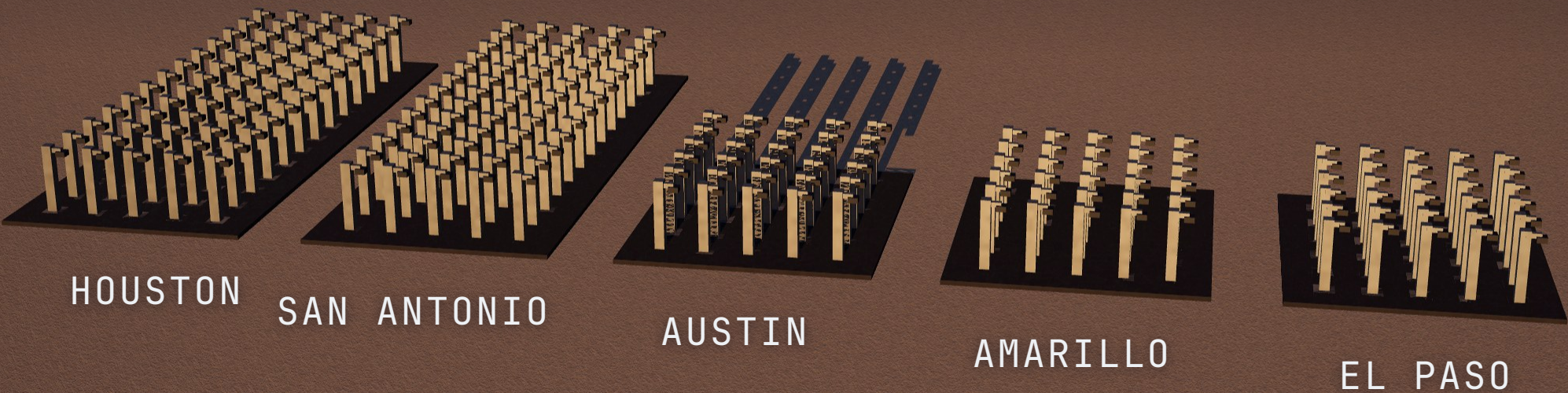
About 63 pounds, fully loaded

The draft gives a wingspan of about 7.8 feet, a length of about 8 feet and a maximum payload of 8 pounds. It calls the aircraft highly automated.



Up to 220 Chargers

Across Amarillo, Austin, El Paso, Houston and San Antonio the draft caps the proposal at 4,400 Dropboxes and 220,000 deliveries a day. Each mast stands for one Charger, which the draft says would typically be 36 docks in three towers of twelve.





It finds no significant impact

The draft ties 400 deliveries a day to places like a large apartment complex. At that rate it estimates delivery noise at no more than DNL 58.1 dB at any distance from a delivery point. It calls 59.7 dB the line below which a rise of 1.5 dB or more can't be significant.

THE DRAFT'S ESTIMATE, DNL 58.1 dB
ITS SCREENING LINE, DNL 59.7 dB

Zipline prepared it

The draft says Zipline prepared it under FAA supervision. Its noise figures rest on testing Zipline collected, in a report ICF prepared for the FAA. The page sets passages from across the draft side by side.

Draft Environmental Assessment for Zipline International Inc. Proposed Drone Package Delivery Operations in Multiple Texas Metropolitan Areas

September 2026

Zipline prepared this draft environmental assessment (draft EA) under the supervision of the FAA

Table 2.2-1. Maximum Number of Zipline Chargers, Dropboxes, and Deliveries per Day by Metro Area

	Area (square miles)	Zipline Chargers	Zipline Dropboxes	Maximum Deliveries per Day	Maximum Transits per Day
Houston	9,932	65	1,300	65,000	195,000
San Antonio	3,326	65	1,300	65,000	195,000
Austin	2,498	30	600	30,000	90,000
Amarillo	1,199	30	600	30,000	90,000
El Paso	629	30	600	30,000	90,000
Total	17,584	220	4,400	220,000	660,000

Noise exposure estimates are provided for the Platform 2 UA (P2 Zip) based on sound level testing data collected by Zipline (2025, 2026).

Comments close October 11th

The draft gives no figure for how often an operator is sent an image. Email 9-FAA-Drone-Environmental@faa.gov and name the Zipline Texas Draft EA in the subject line.